

STAGE ONE • SELF-AWARENESS & CAREER CLARITY

FIRSTS

FACILITATOR GUIDE

Learning objectives, talking points, and misconceptions to preempt for all 18 FIRSTS

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Facilitator Guide

Stage One • Self-Awareness & Career Clarity

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

This guide is for whoever is facilitating Stage One, live or on video, individually or in a cohort. It sits alongside the FIRSTS Manual and Templates workbook — it does not replace them. Where the manual explains a FIRST in depth for a solo reader, this guide is written for someone standing in front of a group, deciding what to actually say and where the conversation is likely to snag.

Each of the eighteen FIRSTS in this stage gets a Learning Objective (what a participant should be able to do by the end, not just “understand”), three Key Talking Points to anchor a short intro before participants work independently or in pairs, and Common Misconceptions to Preempt — the specific wrong turns real participants tend to take, worth naming before they happen rather than correcting after.

This guide is organized into the same three sessions as the companion Session Plan document: Foundations of Self (FIRSTS 01-06), Aligning with the Market (07-12), and Working Style & Systems (13-18). Suggested times are for the group discussion and framing portion only — independent worksheet time is scheduled separately in the Session Plan.

SESSION 1

Foundations of Self

Covers *FIRSTS* 01–06

FIRST 01

Core Values Audit

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants leave with three named, non-negotiable values and can explain what a violation of each looks like in practice.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Values are not the same as preferences. A preference (e.g., “I’d like a short commute”) is negotiable; a value (e.g., “I won’t work somewhere that asks me to mislead people”) is not.
- Misalignment between personal values and a workplace is one of the most common, least-discussed causes of early-career burnout and job-hopping.
- The goal today isn’t a perfect list — it’s three genuinely non-negotiable principles they can actually use as a filter on a real offer.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- “My values are whatever my family/culture told me they should be.” Prompt them to distinguish inherited values from ones they’d choose independently.
- “I need ten values to be thorough.” More than three stops being usable as a decision filter — push for genuine prioritization.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST 02

Career Vision

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants draft a Future Self Letter describing a specific, personally meaningful (not prestige-driven) professional future.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A career vision is a compass, not a rigid endpoint — it should guide decisions, not lock someone into a single fixed path.
- Vague visions (“I want to be successful”) don’t actually help evaluate opportunities. Push for specificity: what role, what impact, what daily life.
- This connects directly to the Core Values Audit — a vision that ignores stated values will feel hollow.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- “My vision has to be the plan I follow exactly.” Reframe as a living document revisited annually, not a contract.
- Defining vision purely by money/title/other people’s expectations rather than genuine purpose.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST 03

Personal Purpose Awareness

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants complete four reflection prompts and condense them into one purpose statement.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Identity is what you do; purpose is why it matters. Purpose is what sustains people through rejection and setbacks.
- Purpose usually isn't a lightning-bolt realization — it's a pattern noticed across small, consistent moments.
- Encourage genuine honesty over an impressive-sounding answer; the prompts work better answered quickly and instinctively than overthought.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- “Purpose has to be big and dramatic (curing cancer, ending poverty).” Most genuine purpose statements are much smaller and more specific than participants expect.
- Waiting for a single defining moment of clarity instead of noticing a pattern over time.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST 04

Personal Brand Narrative

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants draft a 3–5 sentence personal narrative using the current identity → strengths → skills → impact structure.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- This is a direct answer to “tell me about yourself” — practice it out loud, not just on paper.
- Specific beats impressive. “I’m passionate about growth” says nothing; a concrete strength or outcome says everything.
- This draws directly on the Strength Inventory and Core Values Audit — if those aren't done yet, this exercise will feel harder than it should.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Overloading with buzzwords (“synergy,” “disruptive,” “passionate”) instead of concrete specifics.
- Sounding rehearsed/robotic — the narrative should sound like something they'd actually say in conversation.

SUGGESTED TIME: 25 min

FIRST 05

Strength Inventory

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants build a two-column strength map (hard skills, soft skills) and identify their top five in each.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Many students under-recognize their own strengths, especially soft skills, because they don't feel like “real” skills.
- A strength should be demonstrable — push past “I'm a good communicator” to “I led three team presentations that got positive client feedback.”
- This becomes direct resume and interview material later in the program.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Confusing enjoying something with being good at it — interest and proficiency aren't the same thing.
- Focusing only on hard skills and neglecting soft skills, which are often what actually differentiates candidates.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST 06

Weakness Awareness

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify two priority weaknesses from real recent challenges and commit to one concrete 30-day action for each.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- The goal is not self-criticism — it's turning vague self-doubt into two specific, actionable growth areas.
- Ask: was this a skill gap, a mindset issue, or a habit? Each requires a different kind of fix.
- This is often the most emotionally loaded exercise of the session — give people real space and don't rush it.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Denial (“I don't really have weaknesses”) or overgeneralizing (“I'm bad at everything”) — both block genuine, specific reflection.
- Naming a weakness only in comparison to a specific peer, rather than in their own genuine developmental terms.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

SESSION 2

Aligning with the Market

Covers *FIRSTS* 07-12

FIRST 07

Passion Alignment

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants build a Passion-Career Mapping Table and identify two “anchor passions” with real career links.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- This is where Strengths (05) and Weaknesses (06) meet genuine interest — passion alone isn't enough without capability, and vice versa.
- Not every passion needs to become a job. The goal is finding the two with the most promising real career links, not forcing all of them.
- Financial reality matters — acknowledge some passions need a bridge (a side project, a related but different role) rather than a direct leap.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Confusing a hobby (“I enjoy gaming”) with a sustainable career passion — enjoyment doesn't guarantee career viability.
- Ignoring financial realities entirely in the name of “following passion.”

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST 08

Industry Insight

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants build a one-page industry brief: three trends, two growth areas, one major challenge, culture notes, five companies to watch.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Entering an interview or internship without real industry context is immediately obvious to interviewers — this closes that gap.
- This should be a living document, not a one-time exercise — revisited as the industry (and their understanding of it) evolves.
- Push past surface facts (job titles, average salary) toward the forces actually shaping the industry right now.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Relying on stereotypes (“all bankers work 100-hour weeks”) instead of genuine current research.
- Researching only roles/salaries while ignoring company culture, which matters just as much for fit.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST 09

Career Path

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants map one role family across entry/mid/senior levels and trace three real professionals' first career moves.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Career paths are rarely a straight ladder — lateral moves and pivots are the norm, not the exception. Normalize this explicitly.
- The LinkedIn Journey Scan is the highest-value part of this exercise — seeing real people's actual first moves demystifies the path.
- This directly sets up Role Research (10) — don't let participants skip straight to researching one role without this broader map first.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Treating career paths as strictly linear, causing anxiety when their own path doesn't look like a straight line.
- Overcommitting to one specific role family without exploring adjacent, possibly better-aligned ones.

SUGGESTED TIME: 25 min

FIRST 10

Role Research

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants complete a Role Fit Map for one target role, comparing required skills against their current proficiency.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- One job posting is not enough data — push for at least three postings to spot what's genuinely common versus one company's quirk.
- Titles vary wildly across companies for similar work — focus the fit map on actual responsibilities, not the title itself.
- If time allows, this is a natural moment to introduce the idea of an informational interview as a next real-world step.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Making a decision based on a single job posting.
- Chasing an exact title rather than the underlying responsibilities and required skills.

SUGGESTED TIME: 25 min

FIRST 11

Salary Benchmarking

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants research one target role's pay across three platforms and set a personal target range.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- This is about confidence, not greed — many participants have never seen real numbers for their target role and default to underestimating themselves.
- A single source skews the picture; cross-checking three sources and adjusting for location is what makes the number usable.
- Total compensation matters, not just base pay — flag benefits, equity, and growth trajectory as part of the real picture.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Relying on one salary source without cross-checking.
- Forgetting to adjust for location or cost of living, or comparing across unrelated industries.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST 12

Career SWOT Analysis

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants write one paragraph each for Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities, and Threats, and name one 90-day priority.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- This is a synthesis exercise — it should feel easier than earlier ones because it's pulling together work already done in 05, 06, 08, and 09.
- The single closing sentence (“what would make the biggest difference in three months”) is the actual point of the exercise — don't let people skip it.
- Watch for participants being either too harsh or too generous with themselves; both distort the analysis.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Being too self-critical (minimizing real strengths) or too generous (avoiding naming real weaknesses).
- Naming weaknesses/threats without committing to any response, which turns awareness into just another list.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

SESSION 3

Working Style & Systems

Covers *FIRSTS* 13-18

FIRST 13

Skill Growth Plan

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants name 3-5 priority skills, define what improvement looks like for each, and set a weekly practice method.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- This turns the Career SWOT's weaknesses/opportunities into a concrete, trackable plan — not a wishlist.
- Fewer skills done deeply beats many skills done shallowly. Push back if someone lists more than five.
- “I took a course” is not the same as “I can do this.” Insist on a practice method with a real, checkable milestone.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Trying to develop too many skills simultaneously, resulting in shallow progress on all of them.
 - Assuming course completion equals actual skill acquisition, rather than deliberate practice.
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SUGGESTED TIME: 25 min

FIRST 14

Personality Assessment

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants complete a personality assessment and write three short reflections on how it shows up in teamwork, learning, and career fit.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- The assessment result is a starting hypothesis, not a verdict — the real value is in the reflection, not the label itself.
- Push participants to connect the result to specific past experiences, not just accept the label abstractly.
- Watch for participants using their type as an excuse (“I’m an introvert so I can’t do public speaking”) — redirect toward adaptation, not limitation.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Treating assessment results as fixed, immutable limits rather than tendencies to understand and work with.
- Using a personality label as an excuse to avoid a genuine growth area.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST 15

Work Style Awareness

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants track their own work patterns for a week and identify what genuinely helps versus hinders their productivity.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- This requires a week of real observation — in a single session, walk through the method and have them start the tracking log today.
- Assuming others share your work style is a common, quiet source of team friction — flag this explicitly.
- This is about optimization and communication (asking for what you need), not building an excuse to avoid discomfort.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Treating work style as a fixed label used to avoid new or uncomfortable challenges.
- Assuming colleagues share the same style and getting frustrated when they don't.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min (plus a week of independent tracking)

FIRST 16

Thinking & Decision-Making Style

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants analyze one real recent decision — information used, people consulted, time taken — and identify what they'd change.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Early-career outcomes are shaped more by decision quality under pressure than by raw talent — this is a genuinely high-leverage skill.
- There's no single “correct” decision style; the goal is matching the style to the context, not always defaulting to one mode.
- Ask directly: did you over-rely on data and ignore instinct, or the reverse? Both are common failure patterns.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming your natural decision style is always correct regardless of context.
- Confusing speed with competence, or hesitation with wisdom.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST 17

Learning Style Awareness

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants test three different study methods on the same topic across three days and compare retention and confidence.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- This is evidence-based, not preference-based — the point is measuring actual retention, not just what feels comfortable.
- This exercise runs over three days; in-session, focus on setting it up clearly and reviewing results in a following check-in.
- Struggling to learn something is very often a method mismatch, not a lack of ability — this reframes a lot of academic self-doubt.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Treating learning style as a fixed preference rather than something to verify against real performance outcomes.
- Using a preferred style as an excuse to avoid a genuinely necessary but less-preferred learning format.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min setup (plus three days of independent practice and a short follow-up)

FIRST 18

Productivity & Focus System

FACILITATOR NOTE: The current manual text for FIRST 18 is a duplicate of FIRST 17's content and needs to be corrected at the source (the Templates workbook for this chapter is fine). Use this guide's content, not the manual's current Chapter 18 body text, until that's fixed.

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants design a personal system for managing attention, energy, and priorities across a real work or study week.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- This is the capstone of the section — it should pull together the Work Style (15) and Thinking Style (16) insights into one practical daily system.
- A system beats willpower: focus on concrete structures (time blocks, a single task list, a defined shutdown ritual) rather than “trying harder.”
- Keep it simple enough to actually sustain — an elaborate system abandoned in a week is worse than a modest one used consistently.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Believing productivity is about willpower or discipline alone rather than a designed system that reduces the need for willpower.
- Copying someone else's productivity system wholesale without adapting it to their own established work and learning style.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min